Kennedy's mind kept returning to that question as the discussion moved on. A few minutes later he asked again: "If it doesn't increase very much their strategic strength, why is it—can any Russian expert tell us—why they?" Without finishing his question, Kennedy continued: "[I]t's just as if we suddenly began to put a major number of MRBMs in Turkey. Now that'd be goddam dangerous, I would think." Undersecretary of State Alexis Johnson interjected a sobering remark: "We did it." Kennedy was unimpressed: "Yeah, but it was five years ago." But Johnson would not give up. "That's when we were short on ICBMs," he told Kennedy. Unknowingly, he pointed at one of the key factors that motivated Khrushchev's actions in Cuba: his lack of long-range intercontinental missiles. But no one continued that line of argument. Kennedy in particular failed to draw the parallel between the Soviet Union and the United States a few years earlier. "But that was a different period then," he told his advisers.[19]

Whatever Khrushchev's motivations were, Kennedy was determined to show the country and the world that he was not a "weak" president, as Eisenhower had suggested, and eliminate the threat to the country. The military solution Kennedy preferred was a surprise surgical strike on the Soviet missiles in Cuba. Unexpectedly, that evening Kennedy's proposal to execute a surgical strike met with united opposition from the most unlikely allies: the State Department, the Department of Defense, and the Joint Chiefs of Staff. The competition between the departments of Defense and State that had characterized much of American history in the twentieth century was simply absent. McNamara and Rusk disliked the president's choice for different reasons. If Rusk, backed by Bundy, wanted to give diplomacy a chance, McNamara was concerned about the effectiveness of the strike, and the chiefs believed that a strike could put the Soviets on alert, complicating the invasion of the island.

McNamara presented his opposition to the president's plan at the very first meeting of the group. He was in favor of a strike only if the Soviet missiles were not yet operational. "Because, *if* they become operational *before* the air strike," argued McNamara during the late-morning session with Kennedy, "I do not believe we can state we can knock them out before they can be launched. And if they're launched there is almost certain to be